for years to come—remained outside the stupidities of typical bureaucracy, as Sarabhai had given the powers to Murthy to take decisions that went beyond the confines of red tape. Murthy inquired about my experience, and I told him about my eighteen months in the sugar factory. I explained that I may not be able to produce an experience certificate from my previous employer since I had quit against his wishes.

Murthy asked me why I left the job, and I told him it was boring. 'Go ahead and apply,' said Murthy.

'And if you get this job and find it as boring as the sugar factory one, you are free to walk out any time.'

I did not have the Rs 5/- postal order which was mandatory for the application. I ran out to a nearby post office and got one. Three days later, I got a call letter for an interview.

I wanted to know more about the nature of the job, but nobody seemed to know what this bunch of young people were doing in a coastal town under the spire of Mary Magdalene Church. Even today, not many know that Thumba—where the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre (VSSC) now stands—is an enviable location for anyone interested in atmospheric and space sciences for the simple reason that it is close to the magnetic equator of the earth. This strategic location came with the advantage of firing sounding rockets above the equator to conduct a series of experiments on upper atmospheric conditions.

All that was to dawn on me much later, but now I was keen on understanding what was in store for me if I landed the job. My brother-in-law came with the news that some of the scientists involved in TERLS were staying in a lodge. As I was entering the lodge, one of the residents, a man in a pale blue shirt and dark trousers was coming down the stairs. I thought he must be involved in the Thumba project and introduced myself as an applicant.

'I am A P J Abdul Kalam, rocket engineer,' he said.

When I told him my intention to know more about TERLS, he asked me to meet his colleague Aravamudan, who was also staying at Indira Bhavan.